

CLINICAL MANIFESTATIONS

Presentation

The presence of any friable, non-healing lesion should raise the suspicion of skin cancer. Frequently, basal cell carcinoma (BCC) is diagnosed in patients who report that the lesion bled briefly, then healed completely, only to recur later. BCC typically develops on sun-exposed areas of the head and neck but can occur anywhere on the body. Common features include translucency, ulceration, telangiectasias, and a rolled border. Clinical characteristics vary among sub-types, which include nodular, superficial, morpheaform (sclerosing), pigmented BCC, and fibroepithelioma of Pinkus (FEP).

Basal Cell Carcinoma Sub-Types

Nodular Basal Cell Carcinoma

Nodular BCC is the most common clinical sub-type (Fig. 115-1). It typically occurs on sun-exposed areas of the head and neck and presents as a translucent papule or nodule, depending on duration. Telangiectasias are commonly present, and the lesion often has a rolled border. Larger lesions with central necrosis are historically referred to as rodent ulcers (Fig. 115-2). The differential diagnosis includes traumatized dermal nevus and amelanotic melanoma.

Pigmented Basal Cell Carcinoma

Pigmented BCC is a variant of nodular BCC characterized by increased melanization. It appears as a hyperpigmented, translucent papule and may be eroded (Fig. 115-3). The differential diagnosis primarily includes nodular melanoma.

Superficial Basal Cell Carcinoma

Superficial BCC most commonly occurs on the trunk and presents as an erythematous, well-demarcated patch that may resemble eczema (Fig. 115-4). An isolated patch of "eczema" that fails to respond to topical treatment should prompt suspicion for superficial BCC.

Morpheaform (Sclerosing) Basal Cell Carcinoma

Morpheaform BCC is an aggressive variant with distinct clinical and histologic features. Lesions often have an ivory-white appearance and may resemble a scar or a small, indurated plaque (Fig. 115-5). This sub-type is more infiltrative and has a higher risk of recurrence.